News Debate: Firefight

Should teens play violent video games?

Warning! Your favorite video games may be hazardous to your health. Call of Duty, Halo, and other top titles arm players with machine guns and similar deadly weapons and send them in search of enemies. Often the more people players gun down, the more points they earn.

The violent games are popular with teens and adults alike, but they don't score big with everyone. Some researchers and lawmakers say the gory games make teens aggressive and violent. They argue that young people shouldn't be allowed to play them without parental consent.

Other researchers disagree, however. They say violent video games are just that—games—and that playing them is no more harmful than watching graphic movies or TV shows. Even the U.S. Supreme Court justices are sticking up for the games. The nation's top judges overturned a California law that barred stores from selling violent video games to minors.

What do you think? Are the intense games harmless fun or hazardous to your health?

Game Stop ...

Violent video games can be just as dangerous as the assault rifles used to gun down the enemy in Medal of Honor, some researchers say. Psychologists Douglas A. Gentile and Craig A. Anderson have been studying the effects of the games for more than 30 years. The Iowa State University professors recently analyzed more than 130 studies of video games and violence. "[We] found consistent evidence that violent games increase desensitization [and] aggressive thoughts, feelings, physiology, and behaviors and decrease helpful behaviors," they say.

Plus, the more teens play, the more the games' savage scenarios sink in, believes Melissa Henson of the Parents Television Council. That group lobbied in support of the California law. When teens play a game repeatedly, the scenarios in it can become a little too real, she says. "Prolonged exposure to violent images, such as violent video games, can result in more aggressive behavior," Henson told *Current Events.* "[The repetition from playing often] reinforces certain ways of thinking, certain patterns of behavior."

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Even some teens think the games are no good. Raven Laddish, 15, of California, avoids titles such as Grand Theft Auto, in which players steal cars and shoot people. “Those types of games don’t really appeal to me,” she told Wired.com. “I just don’t feel that it’s a good message to send to teens.”

Play On ...

The assault on violent video games needs to stop, says psychologist Christopher Ferguson. “Although there are some studies that find links between violent games and mild forms of aggression, there are also studies which find no evidence for any links at all,” he told *CE.* The Texas A&M International University assistant professor is conducting his own long-term study on video games’ effects on youth violence and bullying. “I’ve found ... no evidence of harmful video game or television violence effects,” he says.

Besides, the games’ combative content isn’t anything most teens haven’t seen before, others argue. In the U.S. Supreme Court’s recent ruling, Justice Antonin Scalia pointed out that even fairy tales are violent. In the original version of “Hansel and Gretel,” for example, the children kill the witch by baking her in an oven. “Certainly the books we give children to read—or read to them when they are younger—contain no shortage of gore,” Scalia wrote in the Court’s decision.

When it comes down to it, teens are smart enough to know the difference between real life and fantasy, says Evan Jones, 16. “[I get] an adrenaline rush during the game, and the need to win, but afterwards it’s just fine,” the California teen told reporters. “I see violent video games as an outlet to aggression and stress.”

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Name: _____ Date: _____

1. What California law did the U.S. Supreme Court recently overturn?

A a law that required minors to stop playing violent video games
B a law that made it a criminal offense to sell violent video games
C a law that banned violent video games from all stores in California
D a law that barred stores from selling violent video games to minors

2. The passage shows two sides of this debate: Should teens play violent video games? According to the passage, what is one argument that teens should be able to play violent video games?

A Prolonged exposure to violent images can change a teen's personality.
B Violent video games sometimes increase aggressive behavior in teens.
C Teens are smart enough to know the difference between real life and fantasy.
D When teens play violent video games, they often confuse fantasy and reality.

3. What can you most likely conclude about how Melissa Henson felt about the Supreme Court ruling described in the passage?

A She was most likely upset about the ruling.
B She was most likely thrilled about the ruling.
C She was most likely indifferent to the ruling.
D She was most likely happy about the ruling.

4. Read this sentence from the passage: "'[We] found consistent evidence that violent games increase desensitization [and] aggressive thoughts, feelings, physiology, and behaviors and decrease helpful behaviors,' they say."

In this sentence, the word **desensitization** means

A foolish thinking
B loss of sensitivity
C confusion
D violent action

5. The author starts the passage with this one-word sentence: "Warning!" Why did the author most likely start the passage this way?

A to exclaim his or her hatred of video games
B to grab the reader's attention from the start
C to warn young kids not to read the passage
D to show how overly dramatic people can be

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6. Who are Douglas A. Gentile and Craig A. Anderson? Where do they work?

_____

_____

_____

7. Why did Justice Antonin Scalia point out that fairy tales are violent? Which sentences from the article support your answer?

_____

_____

_____

8. The question below is an incomplete sentence. Choose the word that best completes the sentence.

Some people argue that playing violent video games causes neither harmful thoughts _____ violent behaviors.

A and
B nor
C for
D as

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9. Answer the following questions based on the sentence below.

Raven Laddish avoids video games such as Grand Theft Auto because those types of games don't appeal to her and she doesn't like the message the games send to teens.

Who? _____

(does) What? avoids video games such as Grand Theft Auto

Why? _____

10. **Vocabulary Word**: reinforces: encourages or supports.

Use the vocabulary word in a sentence: _____

_____

_____

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